

South America



Herbal medicine is a part of the struggle for survival for the indigenous peoples of South America, as they seek to protect their culture and natural habitats. As the great rainforests disappear we are losing thousands of plant species, some of which may have had great medicinal value.

Herbal medicine in South America conjures up images of shamanistic rituals and a collection of thousands of as yet unclassified plants under the thick canopy of the rainforest. But these are only two facets of the continent's herbal tradition—those of the Amazon and Orinoco regions. Distinctly different plants and practices are found in other areas, for example on the Bolivian Andes plateau, on the humid plains of Paraguay, and in cities such as Rio de Janeiro.

Wealth of Native Plants

Ever since the Spanish conquest in the early 16th century, European writers have remarked on the huge variety of plant medicines used by native peoples. The most important of these was cinchona (*Cinchona* spp., p. 80), a traditional Andean fever remedy, which the Spaniards first discovered around 1630. Quinine, produced from this plant, became the most effective treatment for malaria for nearly 300 years and is still widely used as a tonic, bitter, and muscle relaxant. Other important plants originating in South America include the potato (*Solanum tuberosum*, p. 271), which was cultivated in over 60 different varieties by the Inca. Its uses are wide-ranging, but it is particularly effective as a poultice for skin conditions. Ipecac (*Cephaelis ipecacuanha*, p. 186)—now commonly found in over-the-counter cough preparations—was taken by Brazilian native peoples to treat amebic dysentery. Maté (*Ilex paraguariensis*, p. 222), which grows in southern regions of the continent, makes a stimulating beverage that is prepared and drunk like tea. Maté has become so popular it is now cultivated in Spain and Portugal as well as in South America.

Since the 1950s, specialist ethnobotanists have lived within native communities, particularly in the Amazon region, where most tribes have a highly developed herbal lore. Their work has resulted in a wealth of knowledge about Amazonian species. Pareira (*Chondrodendron tomentosum*, p. 189), a climbing vine of the rainforest, for example, yields the poison curare used in hunting, and is taken medicinally to treat water retention, bruising, and insanity. Sadly, however, the herbal medicine of many indigenous groups is now under threat as the rainforests, and their culture, disappear.

Mind-altering Remedies

Notorious in the West as the source of cocaine, coca (*Erythroxylum coca*, p. 206) is an important medicine in South America for nausea and vomiting, toothache, and asthma. It is also completely interwoven into the culture of indigenous Amazonian and Andean peoples and serves as a precise example of the unique

Cinchona (*Cinchona* spp., p. 80) contains quinine, which is a powerful antimalarial.

Nasturtium (*Tropaeolum majus*, p. 278) is a traditional Andean remedy for wounds and chest infections. It is strongly antibiotic.

Arrowroot (*Maranta arundinacea*, p. 233) is used to treat diarrhea and skin conditions, and to heal wounds.

Lemon verbena (*Lippia citriodora*, p. 228) has sedative qualities and is taken as a calming infusion.

Fresh lemon verbena leaves

Dried lemon verbena leaves

Boldo (*Peumus boldo*, p. 246) is a liver tonic.

Fresh boldo leaves

Dried boldo leaves